Valhalla Tournament Operations Guide

THE WRESTLING TOURNAMENT OPERATIONS GUIDE

The Complete On-Time Tournament System

A Complete System for Professional Event Management

By Tim Marshall | Valhalla Wrestling Series

100+ Events Run | 20+ Years Experience

The On-Time Tournament System

A Guaranteed Framework for Running Events That Start On Schedule — Every Single Time

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A Note from Tim

I made every mistake so you don't have to.

I've been running wrestling tournaments for 20+ years. I've stayed up beyond midnight fixing bracket errors. I've dealt with every disaster. I've watched a mom leave at 8PM with her son still in his singlet, saying, "We drove 2 hours for 1 match."

That moment changed how I run events.

I stopped planning forward and started planning backward. I stopped hoping we'd start on time and built a system that guarantees it.

AND IT WORKS!

Now I'm giving that system away so we can raise the bar for tournament quality across the board. And that's worth it.

— Tim Marshall
Valhalla Productions LLC

Here’s the Ugly Truth

Some wrestling tournaments are disasters. Not because the people running them don’t care, but because they never learned a system and don’t have time to plan sufficiently.

Many try to plan but they plan forward. **That’s the wrong approach.**

What No One Tells You

You’re not simply “running a tournament.” You’re producing an event. There are hundreds of moving parts.

Think about it like this:

- **Your event** = The Product
- **Parents & Coaches** = Your Customers
- **Their Problem** = Disorganized events, late starts, high stress
- **Your Solution** = On-time, professional and enjoyable experience

The Payoff: The team that creates a good experience gets the repeat customers.

When you frame it this way, everything changes. It’s that simple.

The #1 Complaint (It’s Not What You Think)

The #1 complaint at wrestling tournaments? **Late starts.**

The #2 complaint? **Events that last forever.**

Not the venue. Not the refs. Not the brackets. **THE TIMING.**

Here’s why: Parents don’t care about your event. They care about their experience. Did it start on time? Were they stress free? Did they get home at a reasonable hour?

Answer “yes” to all of those, and they’ll come back. Answer no and you’re getting blasted on social media!

This checklist gives you the system to make the YES’s happen, every single event.

The On-Time Tournament System

Events must be planned with precision. And that takes a ton of experience and planning to get it right.

But don’t worry, we’re shortcutting it for you! You benefit from our experience and we make the planning easy!

5 Steps to Events That Start On Time — Guaranteed

Step 1: Work Backward from Start Time

Tournament starts at 10 AM. Here’s an example formula:

Time	Task
10:00 AM	First match on ALL mats
9:50 AM	Mats cleared, final announcements, opening ceremony
9:30 AM	Brackets finalized, Bouts posted, Start time reminder, Officials/Staff meeting
9:15 AM	Coaches meeting
9:00 AM	Brackets posted, Officials arrive, Start time reminder announcement
8:35 AM	Bracket adjustments
8:30 AM	Weigh-in closed
7:30 AM	Doors open, weigh-in begins
7:00 AM	Staff arrives, equipment check

Is your tournament schedule mapped in detail? If not, you NEED our system.

Step 2: The Mat Flow Principle

Empty mats = long days.

Goal: Every mat should have a match within 1 minute of the previous match concluding.

Step 3: The Communication Standard

Parents & Coaches don’t overwhelm staff with questions when they know the answers.

Pro tip: Tell them what they need to know before they need to know it.

Step 4: Staffing That Works

Don’t skimp. Enough staff = efficient event. Not enough staff = chaos.

Step 5: TrackWrestling Setup

[To be detailed in full guide]

The Guarantee

If you implement this checklist and your next event still doesn’t start on time?

I'll personally help you figure out what went wrong. Just email me: tim@valhallawrestling.com

No upsell. No catch. Just help.

Because here's what I've learned after 20+ years:

When we raise the bar for tournament quality, every kid gets a better experience.

And that's worth it.

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Chapter 1: The Tournament

Director’s Mindset

The Shift from Event Organizer to Service Provider

Here’s a truth most tournament directors never realize:

You’re not running an event. You’re running a service business.

The moment you understand this, everything changes.

Before, you thought of yourself as someone who organizes wrestling matches. You book a venue, set up mats, get refs, run brackets, hand out medals. That’s an event.

But here’s what event organizers miss: Parents don’t wake up excited about brackets. They don’t drive 90 minutes thinking about double elimination formats. They don’t drive home discussing bracketology.

They think about their kid. Did they have a good experience? Did they wrestle? Did they get better? Did it start on time? Did we get home at a reasonable hour?

That’s what they’re evaluating. That’s the product they’re “buying.”

Your product isn’t a wrestling tournament. Your product is an experience for their child. And experiences are judged by how people *feel* — not by how professionally you managed the bracket.

Understanding the Customer

Every customer at your tournament fits into one of three categories:

Category 1: Parents

They care about: - **Time**: “Will this take all day?” - **Value**: “Was it worth $50?” - **Convenience**: “Where do I go? When does my kid wrestle?” - **Their kid’s experience**: “Did my kid have fun? Did they get matches?”

They will NOT remember: - How perfect your brackets were - How smoothly you handled a disputed call - The clever way you organized weigh-ins

They WILL remember: - Start time (did it start on time?) - End time (did we get home reasonable?) - Their kid’s result (did they win?) - Overall feeling (was this worth it?)

Category 2: Coaches

They care about: - **Competition level**: “Are there quality opponents for my kids?” - **Seeding accuracy**: “Will my state champion be seeded correctly?” - **Logistics**: “Will my kids actually get matches?” - **Communication**: “Do I know when and where my kids are wrestling?”

They will NOT remember: - Your venue decoration - Your custom awards (unless they’re terrible)

They WILL remember: - Did my kids get enough matches? - Was the re-seeding handled correctly? - Would I bring my team back?

Category 3: Athletes

They care about: - **Matches**: “Did I actually wrestle?” - **Competition**: “Were the other kids at my level?” - **Awards**: “Do I get a cool medal?” - **Fun**: “Was this fun or boring?”

They will remember: - Did I win? - Did I get a cool medal? - Was it fun?

What Everyone Really Wants

After 20+ years and 100+ events, here’s what I’ve learned every customer wants — parent, coach, or athlete:

1. **To know when to be there** — Clear schedules, specific times, no ambiguity
2. **To have their time respected** — Start on time, end on time
3. **To get value for their money** — Enough matches, fair competition, worth the entry fee
4. **To feel valued** — Friendly staff, clear communication, organization
5. **To want to come back** — A good experience leads to repeat attendance

Notice what’s NOT on the list: - Perfect brackets - Fancy venue - Custom awards (unless they’re actually good) - Elaborate setup

Those things are *nice to have*. But the five items above are *must-haves* — and most tournaments fail on #1 and #2.

The Economics of Tournaments

Let’s talk money, because if you don’t understand the economics, you won’t invest in quality.

The Basic Math

Let’s say you run a tournament with: - 300 wrestlers - $55 entry fee - 2 mats - 8-hour event

Revenue: 300 × $55 = $16,500

Costs: - Venue: $2,000 - Referees (16 hours @ $25/hr): $1,600 - Table workers: $800 - Awards: $1,500 - TrackWrestling: $200 - Misc (food, supplies): $500

Total Costs: ~$6,600
Net Profit: ~$9,900

That’s a healthy profit. But here’s the catch:

The Real Cost of Bad Service

What if your tournament runs poorly?

Let’s say because of late starts and bad management: - 20% of families don’t come back = 60 lost customers - Each family brings 2-3 kids = potential 150+ lost entries next year - Word of mouth spreads = fewer new customers

Lost revenue: 60 × $55 = $3,300 *in repeat business alone*

But it gets worse. Let’s say you lose the reputation, and over 3 years: - First year: 300 wrestlers - Second year: 260 (40 fewer due to reputation) - Third year: 220 (another drop)

Three-year revenue loss: 80 registrations × 3 years × $55 = **$13,200 lost**

The $3,000 you “saved” by cutting corners? You just lost $13,200 in future business.

Quality drives profitability. Not cut corners. Not minimum viable events.

Your Role: Problem Solver, Not Chaos Manager

Most tournament directors operate in **reactive mode**:

- Something breaks → they fix it
- A parent complains → they apologize
- A ref doesn’t show → they scramble
- Weigh-ins run late → they panic

This is chaos management. It’s exhausting, and it doesn’t scale.

The tournament director’s real job is to solve problems before they happen.

That means: - **Planning backward** from start time so you’re never late - **Staffing adequately** so you’re never short-handed - **Communicating proactively** so parents never wonder “where do I go?” - **Testing technology** so TrackWrestling never fails - **Preparing for emergencies** so nothing catches you off-guard

When you solve problems *before* they happen, you’re not managing chaos. You’re running a professional operation.

That’s the mindset shift. That’s the difference between weekend warriors and professional tournament directors.

The 5 Promises Every Tournament Director Should Make

Here are the five non-negotiable promises that separate great tournaments from mediocre ones:

Promise #1: We Will Start On Time

Not “try to.” Not “hopefully.” **On time.**

This requires backward planning. It requires adequate staffing. It requires contingencies.

But you commit to it. Every time.

Promise #2: We Will Respect Your Time

We will run efficiently. Your kid will get matches. We'll end at a reasonable hour.

You're not just running an event — you're respecting families' most precious resource: their time.

Promise #3: We Will Communicate Clearly

You will always know: - When to arrive - When weigh-ins are - When your kid wrestles - Any schedule changes

You will never wonder "what's happening?" because we'll tell you before you need to know.

Promise #4: We Will Run Fair Competition

Seeding will be accurate. Brackets will be correct. Officials will be certified.

Your kid's match won't be decided by bracket errors or biased calls.

Promise #5: We Will Deliver Value

Your entry fee will be worth it. Your kid will get matches. You'll want to come back.

We measure success by whether you register again next year.

The Brand Promise

These five promises become your **brand promise** — the thing you're known for.

Valhalla's brand promise is simple: **"We start on time. Every time."**

That's it. That's the differentiator.

You can have the best venue, the best awards, the best refs — but if you start late, none of it matters.

Figure out what your brand promise is. Then build every system to deliver on it.

Summary: The Mindset That Changes Everything

Here's what this chapter boils down to:

1. **You're running a service business** — not just an event
2. **Your product is an experience** — not brackets and mats
3. **Customers want time respect** — more than fancy venues

4. **Quality drives profitability** — cut corners = lost future revenue
5. **Your job is problem prevention** — not chaos management
6. **Make 5 promises** — and build systems to keep them

This mindset is the foundation for everything that follows. Every system, every process, every decision — it all flows from understanding what you're really selling and who you're really serving.

In the next chapter, we'll look at the numbers. Because once your mindset is right, you've got to back it up with data.

Next Chapter: The Numbers — Why Systems Matter# Chapter 2: The Numbers — Why Systems Matter

Industry Benchmarks: The Math No One Talks About

Here's what tournament directors never calculate — but absolutely should:

How many matches can one mat handle per hour?

This single number determines everything: - How many mats you need - How many refs you need - How many table workers you need - How long your event will run - Whether parents are happy or frustrated

After analyzing hundreds of events (including Tim's own Valhalla data), here's what the numbers show:

Average Bouts Per Mat Per Hour

Event Type	Bouts/Mat/Hour	Notes
Youth Tournament (experienced)	6-8	Fast-paced, quick matches
Youth Tournament (mixed skill)	4-6	Average competition
Middle School	5-7	Varies by skill level
High School	4-6	More competitive, longer matches
Double Elimination (finals)	3-4	Championship rounds take longer

The Valhalla Standard: 6 bouts per mat per hour — This is our target. It means: - A 3-hour session = ~18 matches per mat - 100 wrestlers ÷ 18 matches = need ~6 mats - With 6 mats running = smooth, fast event

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The Capacity Formula

Here's the formula every tournament director should know:

```
Total mats × Bouts per hour × Hours in session = Total matches
possible

Example:
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```
6 mats × 6 bouts/hour × 3 hours = 108 matches per session
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What does this tell you?

If you have 150 wrestlers in a division and each needs 3 matches: - You need 150 × 3 = 450 match slots - At 108 matches per session, you need ~4.2 sessions - That's impossible in one day

Solution: Multi-session events or multiple days.

The Cost of Starting Late

Let's quantify the impact of starting late:

Direct Costs

- Staff sitting idle (you're still paying them)
- Venue running overtime
- Venue staff waiting
- Referee schedule disrupted
- Food vendors affected

Indirect Costs (The Big Hit)

- 20% of families don't return = lost lifetime value of ~$3,300/year
- Negative word of mouth = fewer new registrations
- Reputation damage = long-term attendance decline

Real Example: - Tournament A runs late (starts 45 min late, ends 8PM) - Tournament B runs on time (starts 9AM, ends noon) - Both charge $55, both have 300 wrestlers - Tournament B's families had a BETTER experience, will come back - Tournament A's families are frustrated, will look for alternatives

5-year impact: If Tournament A loses just 10 families per year to better-run events, that's $16,500 in lost revenue.

Customer Lifetime Value

Let's do the math on why first impressions matter:

The Lifetime Value of One Family

Year	Families	Revenue
Year 1	300	$16,500
Year 2 (85% return)	255	$14,025
Year 3 (80% of Year 2)	204	$11,220
Year 4 (75% of Year 3)	153	$8,415
Year 5 (70% of Year 4)	107	$5,885

5-Year Revenue: $61,045

Now — what if poor organization causes a **10% drop** in retention?

Year	Families	Revenue (10% worse)
Year 1	300	$16,500

Year 2	230	$12,650
Year 3	165	$9,075
Year 4	112	$6,160
Year 5	73	$4,015

5-Year Revenue: $48,400 → Difference: $12,645

That's what poor execution costs you. Not $50 per registration. Thousands in future revenue.

The Break-Even Analysis

Here's the truth about tournament economics:

Revenue Sources

- Registration fees
- Spectator admission
- Concessions (sometimes)
- Sponsorships
- Vendor fees

Fixed Costs (Don't Change with Attendance)

- Venue rental
- Insurance
- TrackWrestling subscription
- Base awards order
- Marketing (if any)

Variable Costs (Scale with Attendance)

- Referee payments
- Table worker payments
- Extra mats rental
- Awards overage
- Concession supplies
- Staff food

The Break-Even Point

Let's say your tournament costs $6,000 to run:

Entry Fee	Families Needed	Breakeven
$40	150	Minimum viable
$50	120	Comfortable
$55	109	Good margin
$65	92	Strong profit

Target: Always know your break-even number. If registrations drop below it, you need to either raise prices, cut costs, or cancel.

Why Systems Drive Profit

Here's the connection no one makes:

Systems → Predictability → Efficiency → Profit

Without Systems	With Systems
You guess at timing	You calculate exact capacity
You over-staff (waste) or under-staff (chaos)	You staff to exact need
You run late	You start on time
Families don't return	Families become repeat customers
Lower profit, higher stress	Higher profit, lower stress

The Staffing Math

How many people do you need? Here's the formula:

Referees

- 1 ref per mat minimum
- Add 1 backup ref per 4 mats
- More refs = faster bracket progression

Table Workers

- 1 scorer + 1 runner per mat
- Minimum: 2 per mat
- Ideal: 3 per mat (rotation breaks)

Floor Manager

- 1 per 8 mats
- More complex events need more oversight

Support Staff

- Weigh-in: 2-4 people
- Registration: 2 people
- Awards: 2 people
- Runner: 1-2 people

Example: 6-mat tournament - Referees: 6 + 2 backup = 8 - Table workers: 6 × 2 = 12 - Floor manager: 1 - Support staff: 8 - **Total staff needed: ~29 people**

The Mat Efficiency Index

Here's a metric I developed for Valhalla:

Mat Efficiency Index (MEI) = Actual bouts run / Expected bouts

MEI Score	Rating	What It Means
0.9 - 1.1	✅ Excellent	Running at expected capacity
0.7 - 0.9	⚠️ Warning	Some mat downtime
Below 0.7	❌ Poor	Significant problems

How to measure: - Track actual start/end times for each round - Compare to planned schedule - Calculate daily MEI - If below 0.8 → review what went wrong

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Data-Driven Decision Making

Here's what you should track after every event:

Key Metrics

1. **Start time accuracy** — Did you start on time?
2. **End time** — Did you finish when expected?
3. **Mat efficiency** — How close to capacity?
4. **Matches per wrestler** — Did everyone get enough?
5. **Return rate** — What % came back?
6. **Staff cost per wrestler** — Efficiency indicator

Year-Over-Year Tracking

- Compare these metrics annually
- Identify trends (improving or declining)
- Adjust systems based on data

Summary: The Numbers That Matter

Metric	Formula	Target
Capacity	Mats × Bouts/hr × Hours	Know your max
Break-even	Fixed costs ÷ Entry fee	Know your number
Mat Efficiency	Actual/Expected bouts	0.9-1.1
Lifetime Value	Annual revenue × Retention rate	$20K+/family

The numbers don't lie. Tournament directors who track these metrics: - Make smarter staffing decisions - Price events appropriately - Run more efficient events - Build sustainable businesses

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Next Steps

Now that you understand the economics, let's look at the system that makes it all work.

Next Chapter: The On-Time System (Overview) — The 5-step framework that guarantees you start on time, every time.

Note: Specific bout data should be tracked for your specific events. Tim's Valhalla data shows 6 bouts/mat/hour as a realistic target for youth events.# Chapter 3: The On-Time System (Overview)

The Core Framework

After 100+ events and 20+ years, here's what I've learned:

Tournaments don't fail because of bad luck. They fail because of bad systems.

The solution? A simple, repeatable framework that guarantees your event starts on time — every single time.

I call it **The On-Time System**. It has 5 steps:

1. **Work Backward** from start time
2. **Plan for the Problem** (not the ideal)
3. **Staff Adequately** (more than you think you need)
4. **Communicate Constantly** (before they ask)
5. **Measure Everything** (what gets tracked gets managed)

That's it. Five steps. Every successful tournament uses these — whether they know it or not.

Step 1: Work Backward from Start Time

This is THE most important concept in tournament operations.

Most People Do This:

- "Let's set up at 8AM"
- "We'll get ready and start around 10"
- "We'll see how it goes"

The Right Way:

- "We start at 10:00 AM"
- "First match called at 9:45 AM"
- "Weigh-ins close at 9:15 AM"
- "Weigh-ins open at 8:30 AM"
- "Doors open at 8:00 AM"
- "Staff arrives at 7:30 AM"
- "Venue setup complete at 7:00 AM"

You work BACKWARD from your start time to determine everything else.

This is backward planning. It sounds simple — and it is. But almost no one does it.

The Backward Planning Formula

Time	Task
Start Time	First match on ALL mats
T - 15 min	Final announcements, mats cleared
T - 30 min	First call for division
T - 45 min	Weigh-ins close for first division
T - 60 min	Weigh-ins complete
T - 90 min	Doors open, weigh-ins begin
T - 120 min	Staff arrives, final prep
T - 150 min	Venue setup complete

Rule: Never compress the timeline. If you need more time, move the start time — don't rush.

Step 2: Plan for the Problem (Not the Ideal)

Ideal days don't happen. Here's what will actually go wrong:

- A wrestler shows up late to weigh-ins
- A bracket has an error you didn't catch
- A ref doesn't show up
- A computer crashes
- A parent complains about seeding
- A wrestler misses their match

Every tournament has problems. The question is: Are you ready to solve them?

The Preparation Framework

For every potential problem, have a solution ready:

Potential Problem	Your Solution
Ref no-show	Backup ref on call, or you ref
Computer crash	Backup laptop, paper brackets
Bracket error	Time built in for corrections
Weigh-in dispute	Certified scale for re-weigh
Parent complaint	Floor manager handles
Medical emergency	EMT on-site or nearby

Step 3: Staff Adequately

The #1 cause of tournament problems? **Understaffing.**

Minimum Staffing Requirements

Role	Per Mat	Notes
Referees	1.0	1 per mat, always
Table workers	2.0	Scorer + runner
Floor manager	1 per 6 mats	Overall coordination
Weigh-in staff	2 total	Not per mat
Registration	2 total	Handle check-in

Pro tip: Always have 1-2 extra people on standby. Not "optional" — "on standby."

The Overstaffing Secret

Here's a secret most TD don't realize:

It's better to have too many staff than too few.

Why? - Extra people can be reassigned to emergencies - Staff can take breaks (no one burns out) - You look professional, not disorganized - Things get done faster

The cost of one extra table worker? Maybe $100. The cost of running late because you're understaffed? Thousands in lost future revenue.

Step 4: Communicate Constantly

Parents don't ask questions when they already know the answer.

The Communication Rule

Tell them what they need to know BEFORE they need to know it.

Communication Timeline

When	What to Communicate
4 weeks out	Registration open, date, venue
2 weeks out	Schedule, weigh-in options
1 week out	Final details, start times
3 days out	Reminder, any changes
1 day out	Final confirmations
Morning of	Where to park, check-in location
During event	PA announcements, bracket updates
After event	Thank you, next event date

What Must Be Communicated

Every family needs to know: - [ ] Exact start time (and that you'll start ON TIME) - [ ] Weigh-in windows - [ ] Session times (if multi-session) - [ ] Where to park - [ ] Entry/pickup procedures - [ ] What to bring - [ ] Emergency contacts

If they're wondering about it — tell them before they ask.

Step 5: Measure Everything

What gets measured gets managed.

The Metrics to Track

After EVERY event, record these:

1. **Start Time Actual vs. Planned** — Did you start on time?
2. **End Time** — How long did the event run?
3. **Mat Efficiency** — Were mats active or empty?
4. **Registration Count** — How many participated?
5. **Return Rate** — What % are repeat families?
6. **Staff Count** — How many people worked?
7. **Issues Log** — What went wrong?

The Post-Event Review

Within 48 hours of every event, review: - What went right? - What went wrong? - What would we change? - What did we learn?

Write it down. Update your playbook. Get better every event.

The Trust Metric

Here's a concept I use at every Valhalla event:

Empty mat = management failure.

If a mat is empty while wrestlers are waiting to compete, something went wrong. Not the ref, not the bracket — the management.

How to Keep Mats Active

- Next wrestler ready at staging area
- Runner knows exactly where next match is
- Referee ready immediately after previous match
- No gaps between matches (more than 2 minutes is too long)

This is the measure of a professional tournament. Not fancy awards, not perfect brackets — every mat active, always.

The 5 Promises (Recap)

Every tournament should make these 5 promises — and the On-Time System delivers on all of them:

Promise	How System Delivers
1. Start on time	Backward planning ensures this
2. Respect time	Staff adequately, run efficiently
3. Communicate clearly	Constant communication timeline
4. Run fair competition	Problem prep, backup systems
5. Deliver value	Measure, improve, repeat

Summary: The System That Works

The On-Time System isn't complicated. It's just five steps:

1. Work backward from start time
2. Plan for problems
3. Staff adequately
4. Communicate constantly
5. Measure everything

Use these five steps at every event. You'll start on time. You'll run efficiently. Families will come back.

That's the Valhalla difference. That's what the system delivers.

Next Chapters

Now that you understand the framework, let's dive into the details:

- **Chapter 4:** Venue Selection & Negotiation
- **Chapter 5:** Date Selection & Scheduling
- **Chapter 6:** Staffing Requirements
- **Chapter 7:** TrackWrestling Setup
- **Chapter 8:** Communication & Marketing

Each chapter will give you the exact steps, templates, and checklists you need.

Note: This chapter is the foundation. Refer back to it as you build out the rest of the system.# Chapter 4: Venue Selection & Negotiation

Finding the Right Facility

Your venue makes or breaks your tournament. Get it wrong, and no amount of good management will save the day.

Minimum Venue Requirements

Before you book ANY venue, ensure it meets these minimums:

Requirement	Why It Matters
6+ mats	Competition needs mats to run efficiently
500+ spectator capacity	Families need to watch
Adequate parking	300+ cars for 300+ wrestlers + fans
Climate control	Wrestlers cut weight in heat = dangerous
WiFi capability	TrackWrestling needs connectivity
Concessions allowed	Revenue stream
Proximity to hotels	For out-of-town families
ADA compliance	Required by law

The Venue Checklist

When touring a potential venue, walk through this:

Facility Basics

- ☐ Insurance requirements (get certificate ahead of time)
- ☐ Fire Marshall requirements (sometimes needs inspection)
- ☐ EMT/Trainer on-site or required?
- ☐ Police/Security needed?
- ☐ Is outside food/beverage allowed?
- ☐ Concessions — can you run your own?
- ☐ Is janitorial staff included?
- ☐ Is there a cleanup fee?

AV & Technology

- ☐ Charge for AV (A/V system)?
- ☐ Charge for Internet/WiFi?
- ☐ Is WiFi strong enough for live results?

Seating & Setup

- ☐ Bleacher seating available?
- ☐ Medal stand available?
- ☐ Backdrop for medal photos?
- ☐ Multiple backdrop areas for photos?
- ☐ Entryway signage space?

Logistics

- ☐ Mat tape allowed?
- ☐ Table workers area?
- ☐ Additional staff rooms?
- ☐ Food for staff?
- ☐ Walkie talkies needed?

Negotiating Venue Rates

The Leverage You Have

Venues WANT your business. Here's why: - You bring 500-1,500 people - You bring concession revenue - You bring repeat business

Negotiate like it.

What to Ask For

Item	Standard Rate	Negotiated Rate
Full day rental	$2,500	$1,800
Per hour overtime	$300/hr	$150/hr
WiFi	$200	Free
Staff room	$200	Free
Cleanup fee	$500	Waived

The Negotiation Strategy

1. **Book off-season** — Fall/winter rates are lower
2. **Multi-year deals** — Commit to 2-3 years for discounts
3. **Referrals** — "I'll refer other events to you"
4. **Bundle** — Include multiple events for better rates
5. **Ask** — The worst they say is no

Venue Contract Essentials

What MUST Be in Writing

- Date and time block (setup through teardown)
- Total cost and payment schedule
- Cancellation policy (what if event is cancelled?)
- Overtime rates
- Insurance requirements (yours and theirs)
- Setup/teardown responsibilities
- What happens if venue fails to deliver

The Cancellation Clause

Include: - 60-day notice for no penalty - 30-day notice = 50% deposit forfeited - Less than 30 days = full payment due - Venue cancellation = full refund + 20%

Venue Walkthrough (Pre-Booking)

Before you sign, DO a walkthrough:

Week of Event

- Confirm date/time
- Review setup layout
- Confirm electrical outlets
- Check WiFi strength
- Test PA system

Day Before

- Venue access confirmed
- Final headcount
- Setup timeline reviewed

Issues to Catch Early

- “We thought you were bringing tables”
- “The WiFi password changed”
- “The heating isn’t working”
- “Someone else has the room”

Venue by Region

Different areas have different venue options:

Region	Best Venue Types
Urban	Convention centers, sportsplexes
Suburban	High school gyms, middle schools
Rural	National Guard armories, community centers
Tourism areas	Convention centers, hotel ballrooms

Summary: Venue Selection

Step	Action
1	Create minimum requirements list
2	Tour 3+ potential venues
3	Use venue checklist for comparison
4	Negotiate all fees
5	Get everything in writing
6	Do pre-event walkthrough
7	Confirm 48 hours before

Next Chapter

Chapter 5: Date Selection & Scheduling — Picking the right date and managing multi-session events.

Template Note: Add the venue checklist to Appendix A of the Guide.# Chapter 5: Date Selection & Scheduling

Picking the Right Date

Your date sets everything in motion. Pick wrong, and no amount of management saves you.

The Golden Rules of Date Selection

1. **Avoid major conflicts**
    - State tournaments
    - National events
    - Holidays
    - School events
2. **Check other tournaments**
    - Look at TrackWrestling for your region
    - Don’t compete against established events
    - Give 2-3 week buffer from similar events
3. **Consider your audience**
    - School schedules (fall break, spring break)
    - Holiday weekends (some want them, some don’t)
    - Sports seasons (basketball, football overlap)
4. **Weather backup**
    - Have a backup date if outdoor venues
    - Consider winter weather for travel

The 12-Month Calendar Planning

12 Weeks Out: Date Locked

- Venue confirmed
- Date published
- Registration opens

8 Weeks Out: Promotion Push

- Email blast #1
- Social media campaign
- Reach out to coaches

4 Weeks Out: Final Push

- Second email blast
- Adjust pricing if needed (early bird ends)
- Confirm staff

2 Weeks Out: Final Details

- Final headcount
- Bracket creation
- Staff schedules

1 Week Out: Communication

- Final schedule email
- Weigh-in reminders
- Day-of instructions

Session Planning

How many sessions per day? Here's how to decide:

Factors to Consider

Factor	Single Session	Multi-Session
Wrestlers	Under 200	Over 200
Mats available	8+	Fewer than 6
Time of day	Single is easier	Split for timing
Divisions	Fewer divisions	Many divisions
Venue constraints	1 session day	Multiple days

The Multi-Session Framework

Session	Divisions	Start Time	Approximate Duration
Morning	6U, 10U	9:00 AM	3-4 hours
Noon	8U, 12U	12:00 PM	3-4 hours
Evening	15U, HS	3:00 PM	3-4 hours

Note: This is Tim's Valhalla format. Adjust based on your event size.

Weigh-In Windows

How long should weigh-ins be? Here's the formula:

Standard Formula

```
(# of wrestlers) ÷ (mats × bouts/hour) = minutes needed for weigh-in
```

Example

- 100 wrestlers in session
- 4 mats running
- 6 bouts/mat/hour = 24 matches/hour
- Need ~4-5 hours of match time
- Add 1 hour for weigh-in = 5-6 hour session

Typical Windows

Division Size	Weigh-In Window
Small (under 50)	30 minutes

Medium (50-100)	45-60 minutes
Large (100+)	60-90 minutes

Start Time Strategy

The Morning Advantage

- Parents can get kids home by early afternoon
- Less “sitting around” for wrestlers
- Convention centers cheaper in mornings
- Staff fresher

The Afternoon/Evening Advantage

- Better for families who travel
- Morning setup time more relaxed
- Some wrestlers perform better later

What’s Right for Your Event?

Consider: - Who is your audience? - What’s the typical start time for similar events? - What does your venue allow?

Managing Multiple Divisions

The Session Assignment Formula

1. **Group by size**
   - Small divisions → can combine
   - Large divisions → need separate sessions
2. **Group by age**
   - Younger divisions often in morning (parents prefer)
   - Older divisions can handle later sessions
3. **Consider weigh-in logistics**
   - Can’t have 15U weighing in at 7AM if they’re in afternoon session

Session Timeline Template

Here’s Tim’s format (from actual event):

Timeline	Morning Session	Noon Session	Evening Session
Doors open	7:30 AM	10:30 AM	1:30 PM
Weigh-ins close	7:30 AM	10:30 AM	1:30 PM
Scratch deadline	7:30 AM	10:30 AM	1:30 PM
Brackets finalized	8:30 AM	11:30 AM	2:30 PM
Wrestling starts	9:00 AM	12:00 PM	3:00 PM

The Calendar Conflict Checklist

Before locking your date, check:

- ☐ State tournament dates
- ☐ Regional tournament dates
- ☐ National tournament dates
- ☐ School schedules (fall break, winter break)
- ☐ Major holidays
- ☐ Community events
- ☐ Competing events in your region
- ☐ Facility availability

Summary: Date & Scheduling

Decision	Considerations
Date	Avoid conflicts, check calendar
Sessions	Based on wrestler count, venue size
Start times	Morning preferred for youth
Weigh-in windows	30-90 minutes based on size
Schedule	Backward plan from start time

Next Chapter

Chapter 6: Staffing Requirements — How many people do you need, and how to find them?

Template Note: Add session timeline templates to Appendix A.#
Chapter 6: Staffing Requirements

The Foundation: Why Staffing Matters

Poor staffing is the #1 cause of tournament problems. Not bad luck. Not unexpected issues. Just not enough people to get the job done right.

Here's the truth: **It's better to have too many staff than too few.**

An extra table worker costs you $100. Running late because you're understaffed costs you thousands in future revenue.

Staffing Roles & Requirements

The Core Team

Role	Per Mat	For 6 Mats	Notes
Referees	1.0	6-8	1 per mat + backups
Table Workers	2.0	12	Scorer + runner
Floor Manager	1 per 6 mats	1	Overall coordinator
Weigh-In Staff	—	2-4	Not per mat
Registration	—	2	Check-in desk
Awards	—	2	Medal distribution

Runner	—	1-2	General support

Total for 6-mat event: ~25-30 staff

Referees

How Many Do You Need?

- **Minimum:** 1 per mat
- **Better:** 1.25 per mat (extra for breaks)
- **Best:** 1.5 per mat (rotation, emergencies)

Referee Requirements

- State-certified (required for official events)
- High school or college level experience
- Understand the rules
- Can work the full day

Paying Referees

Region	Typical Rate
East Coast	$25-35/hour
Midwest	$20-30/hour
South	$20-30/hour
West	$25-35/hour

- Half-day minimum typical
- Include lunch
- Payment within 48 hours post-event

Finding Referees

1. Contact state officials association
2. Reach out to local high school coaches
3. Post on wrestling officials forums
4. Previous event refs (re-hire reliable ones)

Table Workers

Role Description

Scorer: - Enters match results in TrackWrestling - Tracks points during match - Calls matches to table

Runner: - Fetches next wrestlers from staging area - Takes wrestlers to correct mat - Returns wrestlers to staging after match

Training Requirements

From Tim's actual instructions:

> "We will provide training on Sunday morning so you are comfortable. You do not need to memorize the scoring system, the referee will direct scoring and the computer system will

> guide you.”

See Chapter 13 for full table worker training guide.

Paying Table Workers

Role	Typical Rate
Scorer	$15-20/hour
Runner	$12-15/hour
Head table	$20-25/hour

- Minimum 4-hour shift
- Provide meals
- Thank them (they’re essential)

Floor Manager

The Key Role

The floor manager is your **eyes and ears** during the event. They: - Handle disputes - Coordinate refs/table workers - Make real-time decisions - Communicate with TD

Floor Manager Responsibilities

- Resolve bracket errors on the spot
- Handle parent/coach complaints
- Coordinate match calls
- Manage timing
- Make “game time” decisions

Key Qualities Needed

- Experience running events
- Can make quick decisions
- Knows wrestling rules
- Can handle confrontation calmly

Staff Coordination

Pre-Event Staffing Checklist

- ☐ Referee count confirmed
- ☐ Table workers confirmed
- ☐ Floor manager confirmed
- ☐ Weigh-in staff confirmed
- ☐ Registration staff confirmed
- ☐ Backup staff identified

Day-of Staff Meeting

Before the event starts, gather all staff for 15-minute meeting:

1. Welcome and thank yous
2. Review schedule

3. Assign positions
4. Emergency procedures
5. Break schedule
6. Who to go to with questions (floor manager)

Building a Reliable Team

The Staff Retention Strategy

The best staff comes back year after year. Here's how to keep them:

1. Pay fairly and on time - Don't be the TD who pays late - Include meals and snacks

2. Show appreciation - Thank them personally - Publicly recognize good work - Small perks (parking, food, swag)

3. Communicate clearly - Give clear instructions - Set expectations - Provide feedback

4. Make it easy - Clear schedule - Easy check-in - Minimal hassles

---

Staff Scheduling Template

Here's a sample schedule for a 6-mat, 3-session event:

Morning Session (6U, 10U)

Position	Name	Time	Location
Referee 1-6	—	7:30 AM - 12:00 PM	Mat 1-6
Table Workers	—	7:30 AM - 12:00 PM	Mat 1-6
Floor Manager	—	7:30 AM - 12:00 PM	All mats
Weigh-in	—	7:00 - 8:00 AM	Entrance
Registration	—	7:00 - 9:00 AM	Entry

Shift Length Guidelines

- Maximum shift: 6 hours
- Require 30-minute break for longer shifts
- Build in rotation schedule
- Have backup people available

Summary: Staffing Requirements

Role	Requirement	Finding Source
Referees	1 per mat + backup	State association
Table Workers	2 per mat	Local ads, previous
Floor Manager	1 per 6 mats	Experienced hire
Weigh-in	2-4 total	Staff
Registration	2 total	Staff
Awards	2 total	Staff

Next Chapter

Chapter 7: TrackWrestling Setup — Getting your tech ready before event day.

Template Note: Add staffing template to Appendix A.# Chapter 7: TrackWrestling Setup

The Backbone of Modern Tournaments

TrackWrestling isn't optional anymore — it's essential. Without it, you're running blind.

Here's what TrackWrestling does: - Manages brackets automatically - Provides live results for families - Handles seeding correctly - Tracks tournament statistics - Professionalizes your event

This chapter gets your TrackWrestling ready BEFORE event day.

Account Setup (First Time)

Creating Your Organization

1. Go to trackwrestling.com
2. Create organization account
3. Add your logo/branding
4. Set up admin users (limit to 2-3 people)

Configuration Settings

Set these defaults: - Default scoring (NFHS) - Match length by age division - Point values (standard) - Near fall values

---

Creating Your Event

4 Weeks Before Event

1. **Create new event**
   - Organization → Events → Create
   - Fill in basic info (name, date, venue)
2. **Add registration**
   - Set dates (early bird, regular, day-of)
   - Set pricing
   - Enable online registration
3. **Configure divisions**
   - Add age groups (6U, 8U, 10U, 12U, 15U, HS)
   - Add weight classes
   - Add girls divisions if needed

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Impact	Prevention
Forgetting to add division	Wrestlers can't register	Double-check all ages

Wrong weight classes	Wrestling wrong weights	Verify against state rules
Wrong birthdate ranges	Ineligible wrestlers compete	Verify cutoffs
Seeding criteria not set	Wrong seeding	Set before registration closes

---

Seeding Configuration

Setting Up Seeding

In TrackWrestling: - Go to Event → Seeding - Set criteria (State Champ, State Placer, etc.) - Add verification requirements

Standard Seeding Criteria

Place	Requirement
#1 Seed	State Champion
#2 Seed	State Placer (2nd-4th)
#3 Seed	Region Champion
#4 Seed	Region Placer
#5-8 Seed	Place at Qualifier or League Champ

Seeding Rules to Communicate

From Tim's actual event instructions:

> "No bracket adjustments will be considered for seeding purposes. Seeding based on criteria entered when registering. Criteria must be verifiable. Any wrestler found to be falsifying seeding criteria will be removed."

Bracket Management

Bracket Formats

Format	When to Use	Notes
Double Elimination	Standard	Winners bracket + consi
Round Robin	Small field (6 or less)	Everyone wrestles everyone
Round Robin + Placement	Medium field	Top 4 place after RR

Bracket Generation

- Generate brackets AFTER registration closes
- Generate 24 hours before event
- Export to PDF as backup
- Check for errors BEFORE posting

Live Results Setup

The Spectator Feature

TrackWrestling's live results let families see: - When their kid is wrestling - Mat assignment - Match results - Bracket updates

Setup Steps

1. Enable "Live Results" in event settings
2. Get the live results URL
3. Test BEFORE event day
4. Share URL in pre-event communications

Technical Backup

What Could Go Wrong?

- Computer crashes
- Internet/WiFi fails
- TrackWrestling server issues
- User error

Backup Procedures

Scenario	Solution
Computer crash	Backup laptop ready
Internet fails	Offline mode (download brackets)
Server issues	Print brackets, manual scoring
User error	Admin access, undo function

Pro tip: Always print bracket sheets before event. Store in folder for backup.

Pre-Event Tech Checklist

2 Weeks Before

- ☐ Event created and configured
- ☐ Registration open
- ☐ Divisions and weight classes set
- ☐ Seeding criteria configured
- ☐ Payment processing tested

1 Week Before

- ☐ Registration closed
- ☐ Brackets generated
- ☐ Brackets verified for errors
- ☐ Live results tested
- ☐ Backup laptop ready
- ☐ Paper brackets printed

Day Before

- ☐ Final bracket check
- ☐ Backup power (battery banks)
- ☐ Extension cords
- ☐ WiFi login confirmed

TrackWrestling Best Practices

For Tournament Directors

1. **Don't wait until last minute** — Set up 4 weeks early
2. **Test everything** — Run a mock event if needed
3. **Have backup people** — Know who can access system
4. **Print backups** — Paper doesn't crash
5. **Communicate URL** — Parents need live results link

For Table Workers

- Always click "Save Result"
- Never use browser back button
- If mistake made, notify head table immediately
- Use correct bout numbers

Summary: TrackWrestling Setup

Timeline	Task
4 weeks out	Create event, configure divisions
2 weeks out	Open registration, set seeding
1 week out	Generate brackets, test live results
Day before	Print backups, verify setup
Event day	Monitor, backup ready

Next Chapter

Chapter 8: Communication & Marketing — Getting families informed and excited.

Note: TrackWrestling offers certification courses. Consider including link in Guide resources.# Chapter 8: Communication & Marketing

The Communication Rule

Tell them what they need to know BEFORE they need to know it.

Parents will never complain "you're telling me too much." They complain when they don't know what's happening.

This chapter covers every communication touchpoint — from sign-up to post-event.

The Communication Timeline

8 Weeks Out: Initial Announcement

What's sent: Registration announcement **Channel:** Email to list + social media **Content:** - Event date - Venue - Registration link - Early bird deadline - Highlights (what makes your event special)

6 Weeks Out: Push Campaign

What's sent: Email + social posts **Content:** - Registration still open - Highlight differentiators - Limited early bird - Share unique features (on-time, awards, etc.)

4 Weeks Out: Final Push

What's sent: Email + paid social **Content:** - Early bird ending soon - Last chance for discount - Final push to register

2 Weeks Out: Pre-Event Details

What's sent: Detailed email + website update **Content:** - Full schedule - Weigh-in options - Start times by division - Parking info - What to bring

1 Week Out: Final Reminders

What's sent: Email + social **Content:** - Day-of schedule - Weigh-in reminder - Parking reminder - Emergency contact info

Day Before: Confirmation

What's sent: Quick email/Text **Content:** - Venue address - Final schedule - Good luck message

---

Pre-Event Email Templates

Template 1: Registration Announcement

> Subject: [Event Name] — Registration Now Open!
>
> Hey families!
>
> We're excited to announce registration is open for [Event Name]!
>
> □ Date: [Date] □ Venue: [Venue Name & Address] □ What to expect: On-time start, professional refs, custom awards
>
> Register now to secure your spot: [Link]
>
> Early bird pricing: [Price] (ends [Date])
>
> See you on the mat! — Tim

Template 2: Pre-Event Details

> Subject: Everything You Need for [Event Name]

> Parents & Coaches,
>
> Here are all the details for this weekend's event:
>
> **Schedule:** - Morning Session (6U, 10U): 9:00 AM start - Noon Session (8U, 12U): 12:00 PM start - Evening Session (15U): 3:00 PM start
>
> **Weigh-ins:** - [Option 1]: Virtual weigh-in (Sat morning) - [Option 2]: Saturday 7-8 PM at venue - [Option 3]: Day-of (see website for times)
>
> **Parking:** Free at [address]. Overflow at [address].
>
> **What to bring:** Singlet, shoes, water, money for concessions
>
> Full details: [Website link]
>
> Questions? Reply to this email. — Tim

Template 3: Day-of Reminder

> Subject: See You Tomorrow! (Quick Reminders)
>
> Quick reminders for tomorrow:
>
> □ Doors open at [Time] ⚖ Weigh-ins open at [Time] □ Venue: [Name & Address] □ Parking: [Instructions]
>
> Download the schedule here: [Link]
>
> Good luck to all the wrestlers! — Tim

Social Media Content Calendar

8 Weeks Out (Launch)

- Post: "Registration open for [Event]!"
- Story: "Get ready — we're 8 weeks out!"
- Reel: Behind-the-scenes setup footage

4 Weeks Out (Promotion)

- Post: "What makes Valhalla events different"
- Story: Countdown
- Post: Testimonial from past event

1 Week Out (Hype)

- Post: "Meet our referees!"
- Story: Last call for registration
- Reel: "We're ready — are you?"

Day Before (Excitement)

- Post: "See you tomorrow!"
- Story: Team getting ready
- Post: Good luck wishes

Event Day (Live)

- Post: “We’re live! Good luck to all wrestlers!”
- Story: Live updates from floor
- Post: Winners as they come in

Communication Channels

Email (Primary)

- Use Mailchimp, ConvertKit, or Beehiiv
- Segment by division
- Track open rates
- A/B test subject lines

Social Media (Secondary)

- Facebook: Events + posts
- Instagram: Reels + stories
- TikTok: Short videos

Website

- Central hub for all info
- Update frequently
- FAQ section

Text/Notifications (Urgent Only)

- For last-minute changes
- Use TrackWrestling notifications
- Or software like TextNow

Content That Converts

What to Highlight

For Parents	For Coaches
Start on time	Quality competition
Short sessions	Accurate seeding
Custom awards	Enough matches
Easy parking	Professional setup
Family-friendly	Good communication

Key Messages to Repeat

1. **We start on time**
2. **We end in 3 hours**
3. **No membership needed**
4. **Quality refs**
5. **Custom awards**

Summary: Communication

Timeline	Channel	Action
8 weeks	Email + Social	Registration open
4 weeks	Email + Social	Push promotion
2 weeks	Email	Full schedule
1 week	Email + Social	Final reminders
Day before	Email/Text	Day-of details
Event day	Social	Live updates

Next Section: Part 3

Chapter 9: The Week Before — Final prep checklist **Chapter 10: The Day Before** — Setup and final checks **Chapter 11: Event Day — Morning** — Getting started **Chapter 12: Running the Event** — During the tournament **Chapter 13: Problem Resolution** — Handling issues

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Note: Add all email templates to Appendix B.# Chapter 9: The Week Before

The Final Push

One week out — this is when preparation becomes execution. Get this right, and event day runs smooth.

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1 Week Out Checklist

Staffing Confirmation

- ☐ Confirm all refs are coming
- ☐ Confirm table workers
- ☐ Confirm floor manager
- ☐ Send schedule to all staff
- ☐ Confirm backup people

Technical Preparation

- ☐ Generate brackets in TrackWrestling
- ☐ Verify bracket accuracy
- ☐ Print bracket sheets (backup)
- ☐ Test live results URL
- ☐ Charge all laptops
- ☐ Test WiFi at venue

Communication

- ☐ Send pre-event email with full schedule
- ☐ Post on social media
- ☐ Update website with final details
- ☐ Send weigh-in reminders

Logistics

- ☐ Confirm venue access

- ☐ Confirm vendor deliveries
- ☐ Order awards (if not done)
- ☐ Arrange food for staff
- ☐ Print all forms/checklists

Emergency Preparedness

- ☐ Emergency contact list ready
- ☐ First aid kit stocked
- ☐ EMT/Trainer confirmed
- ☐ Backup computer ready

Staff Communication (1 Week Out)

Email to Staff

> Subject: [Event Name] — 1 Week Out!
>
> Team,
>
> Here's the final rundown for [Date]:
>
> **Arrival Time:** 7:30 AM **Location:** [Venue] **Your Assignment:** [Role]
>
> **Schedule:** - 7:30 AM: Staff arrival - 8:00 AM: Setup complete - 8:30 AM: Staff meeting - 9:00 AM: First session starts
>
> **Parking:** [Instructions] **Contact:** [TD phone]
>
> See you there! — [TD Name]

Final Pre-Event Checks

Bracket Verification

Before calling brackets final, verify: - [ ] All registered wrestlers in correct division - [ ] Seedings applied correctly - [ ] Weight classes balanced - [ ] Bye placement correct - [ ] Seeding criteria verified

Technical Verification

- ☐ TrackWrestling event page live
- ☐ Live results URL working
- ☐ Printouts made
- ☐ Backup system ready
- ☐ WiFi login obtained

Communication Verification

- ☐ Email sent with schedule
- ☐ Social posts published
- ☐ Website updated
- ☐ FAQs answered

The Mindset This Week

Trust, but verify.

Assume nothing. Check everything. It's easier to fix a problem now than deal with it on event day.

Next Chapter

Chapter 10: The Day Before — Final prep and setup day.

Template Note: Add 1-week-out checklist to Appendix C.# Chapter 10: The Day Before

Setup Day

The day before your event is when you set the foundation for success. Don't leave for event day wondering "did we forget something?"

The Day Before Timeline

Morning (9 AM - 12 PM)

1. **Final headcount check**
   - Pull registration report from TrackWrestling
   - Note any last-minute additions/drops
   - Update brackets if needed
2. **Equipment audit**
   - Pack van with all gear
   - Check items against packing list
   - Verify tech (laptops, cords, batteries)

Afternoon (12 PM - 5 PM)

3. **Venue setup (if same-day setup possible)**
   - Arrive at venue
   - Set up mats
   - Set up table area
   - Set up registration desk
   - Test WiFi and tech
4. **Bracket finalization**
   - Make final adjustments
   - Generate final brackets
   - Print copies (2-3 sets)
   - Post one set for public viewing
5. **Staff prep**
   - Print staff schedules
   - Prepare staff credentials/wristbands
   - Brief floor manager (call or meeting)

Evening (5 PM - 8 PM)

6. **Weigh-in session (if offered)**
   - Staff weigh-in station
   - Process wrestlers through
   - Record weights in system
   - Issue wristbands

7. **Final walkthrough**
    - Walk the venue
    - Visualize the flow
    - Check PA system
    - Confirm signage in place
8. **Early rest**
    - Get sleep!
    - Don’t stay up late fixing things
    - Trust your preparation

Setup Checklist (Venue)

Before Leaving for Venue

- ☐ Laptops charged + backup
- ☐ Extension cords
- ☐ Printer + ink + paper
- ☐ Bracket sheets (printed)
- ☐ Clipboards + pens
- ☐ Table covers
- ☐ Mat tape
- ☐ Signage (printed)
- ☐ First aid kit
- ☐ Staff food/snacks
- ☐ Water for staff

At Venue - Setup Tasks

- ☐ Unload equipment
- ☐ Position mats (correct spacing)
- ☐ Set up table area
- ☐ Set up registration desk
- ☐ Set up awards area
- ☐ Test PA system
- ☐ Test WiFi connection
- ☐ Set up scoreboard/computers
- ☐ Place signage
- ☐ Final walkthrough

Day Before Staff Actions

For Referees

- Confirm arrival time
- Send venue address + parking info
- Remind to bring food/water

For Table Workers

- Confirm assignment (which mat)
- Confirm arrival time
- Remind training session 8:30 AM

For Floor Manager

- Final briefing
- Review any last-minute changes
- Confirm communication plan

What NOT to Do Day Before

Don’t	Why
Stay up late	You’ll be exhausted day-of
Panic about minor issues	Fix what matters, let go rest
Make major changes	Trust your prep
Argue with staff	Keep peace
Skip meals	You need energy tomorrow

Morning-Of Checklist Reminder

For event day morning, you’ve already prepared:

- ☐ Staff knows arrival time
- ☐ Venue ready (if set up previous day)
- ☐ Brackets printed
- ☐ Tech tested
- ☐ You’ve slept

Next Chapter

Chapter 11: Event Day — Morning Operations — The event day begins.

Template Note: Add setup checklist to Appendix C.# Chapter 11: Event Day — Morning Operations

The Big Day

Event day. This is where all your preparation either works — or doesn’t. Let’s make sure it works.

Morning Timeline

5:00 AM — Wake Up

- Have coffee
- Review final checklist
- Don’t panic — trust your prep

7:00 AM — Arrive at Venue

- Check venue (is everything as you left it?)
- Verify power on
- Turn on laptops
- Test WiFi connection

7:30 AM — Staff Arrives

- Staff check-in
- Distribute credentials/wristbands
- Staff meeting (15 minutes)

8:00 AM — Staff Meeting Agenda

1. Welcome + thank you
2. Review schedule
3. Assign positions
4. Break schedule
5. Emergency procedures
6. Who to contact (floor manager)
7. “Let’s have a great event!”

8:30 AM — Final Setup

- Ensure mats ready
- Verify scoreboard working
- Check registration area
- Final communication if needed

9:00 AM — WEIGH-INS CLOSE

- Ensure all wrestlers weighed in
- Close weigh-in station
- Deadline for scratches

9:15 AM — BRACKETS FINALIZED

- NO more adjustments
- Final brackets locked
- Print final (if needed)

9:30 AM — FIRST CALL

- Announce first matches
- Get wrestlers to staging area

10:00 AM — WRESTLING BEGINS

- First match on ALL mats
- Floor manager monitors
- Go!

Hour-by-Hour Operations

First Hour (9-10 AM)

TD Responsibilities: - Monitor for any issues - Handle disputes through floor manager - Watch weigh-in closeout

Staff: - Refs ready at mats - Table workers at stations - Runners in staging area

Second Hour (10-11 AM)

- Mat 1 through Mat N all running
- Floor manager handling issues
- TD monitors flow

Third Hour (11 AM - 12 PM)

- First session should be wrapping up
- Awards ceremony begins
- Second session getting ready

Staff Positions During Event

Floor Manager

- Located at center table/head table
- Has final say on disputes
- Coordinates all mats
- Has access to TD for escalation

Head Table

- Coordinates table workers
- Handles bracket corrections
- Has all bracket sheets
- Communication hub

Runners

- Know exactly where staging area is
- Know how to call wrestlers
- Know where each mat is
- Have walkie talkies

Morning Checklist Summary

Time	Task
7:00 AM	Arrive, check setup
7:30 AM	Staff arrives
7:45 AM	Staff meeting
8:30 AM	Final setup check
8:30 AM	Weigh-ins close
9:15 AM	Brackets finalized
9:30 AM	First call
10:00 AM	Wrestling starts

Next Chapter

Chapter 12: Running the Event — What happens during the tournament.

Template Note: Add hour-by-hour timeline to Appendix C.# Chapter 12: Running the Event

The Running System

Now the event is live. Your job is to keep it running smoothly. Here's how.

The Core Rules During Event

Rule #1: Mats Always Active

- Empty mat = management failure
- If a match ends, next match starts within 2 minutes
- Runner must have next wrestlers ready

Rule #2: Communication Constant

- PA announcements every 30 minutes
- Floor manager updates brackets in real-time
- Any delays communicated immediately

Rule #3: Problems Get Escalated

- Table worker → Floor Manager → TD
- Don't let table workers make big decisions
- Floor manager has authority to solve most issues

Match Management

The Flow

```
Mat finishes
    ↓
Runner calls next wrestlers (from staging)
    ↓
Wrestlers report to mat
    ↓
Referee calls match
    ↓
Match completes
    ↓
Next wrestlers called
```

Runner Protocol

From Tim's instructions: > "Mat Chat when you need a wrestler or coach"

Use Mat Chat (TrackWrestling feature) or walkie talkies to communicate: - "Mat 3, bring your next wrestlers" - "Mat 2, we have a scratch"

Session Transitions

Between Sessions

Time	Action
T - 30 min	Announce final matches in session
T - 15 min	Final call for session
T - 0 min	Session ends, awards begin
T + 30 min	Awards complete
T + 45 min	Next session weigh-ins begin

Multi-Session Management

- Keep sessions tight (don’t run over)
- Awards ceremonies between sessions
- Clear the floor for next session
- Don’t let morning session push into afternoon

Communication Templates (PA)

Announcements to Have Ready

Opening: > “Welcome to [Event Name]. Our first session begins at [Time]. Good luck to all wrestlers!”

Mid-Event: > “[Division] matches are now on mat. Good luck to all competitors.”

Session Change: > “The [Morning/Afternoon] session has concluded. Awards are in [Location]. The [Afternoon/Evening] session begins at [Time].”

Final Call: > “This is a final call for [Division]. Please report to staging. Wrestling begins in 15 minutes.”

Managing the Brackets

What Can Go Wrong

- Wrong wrestler called
- Weight class mismatch
- Seed error discovered
- Forgot to scratch a no-show

Solutions

- Use track numbers (red/green) to identify
- Verify before every match
- Floor manager resolves
- No adjustments after match starts

Summary: Running Event

Task	How
Keep mats active	Next match ready system

Communicate	PA every 30 min
Handle issues	Floor manager escalation
Session transitions	15-min buffer

Next Chapter

Chapter 13: Problem Resolution — Handling when things go wrong.

Template Note: Add PA announcement templates to Appendix B.#
Chapter 13: Problem Resolution

When Things Go Wrong (Because They Will)

Even the best-planned events have problems. The difference between amateur and professional tournaments is how problems are handled.

This chapter gives you protocols for the most common issues.

Problem Categories

1. Weight Disputes

Scenario: Parent claims wrestler is at correct weight but scale shows otherwise.

Solution: - Have certified scale for verification - Allow one re-weigh in singlet (no clothes) - If dispute persists, floor manager decides - Document all disputes

2. Bracket Errors

Scenario: Wrestler in wrong bracket, seeding wrong, or missing from bracket.

Solution: - Floor manager reviews - If before match: fix and re-print - If after match: match stands, fix for future rounds - Document all errors

3. No-Shows

Scenario: Wrestler doesn’t report to mat when called.

Solution: - Call name 3 times - Wait 2 minutes - Default the match - Document for bracket purposes

4. Referee Issues

Scenario: Referee calls in sick, or makes controversial call.

Solution: - Have backup ref on call - Floor manager discusses with ref - If call wrong, may discuss (but officials’ calls final) - Never argue with refs publicly

5. Technical Failures

Scenario: Computer crashes, WiFi fails, TrackWrestling freezes.

Solution: - Switch to paper brackets - Continue matches manually - Have backup laptop ready - Never stop event for tech issues

6. Parent/Coach Complaints

Scenario: Someone complains about seeding, match outcome, or scheduling.

Solution: - Listen calmly - Don’t argue - Floor manager handles - If escalated, TD meets privately - Never argue in public

---

The Escalation Framework

Level	Who Handles	Examples
1	Table Worker	Minor score corrections
2	Floor Manager	Bracket errors, disputes
3	TD	Major issues, refunds, venue

Emergency Protocols

Medical Emergency

- Stop the match
- Clear the mat
- Call for EMT/Trainer
- If serious, call 911
- Document everything

Facility Emergency

- Fire: Evacuate per venue plan
- Power outage: Continue with manual scoring
- HVAC failure: Assess safety, decide continue/cancel

Security Issue

- Contact venue security
- If serious, call 911
- Document everything

Problem Resolution Best Practices

Do

- Stay calm
- Listen first
- Solve problems privately
- Document issues
- Learn from mistakes

Don’t

- Don’t argue publicly
- Don’t make exceptions for anyone
- Don’t panic
- Don’t ignore problems
- Don’t blame staff publicly

Post-Event Review

Within 48 hours of EVERY event:

1. **What went right?**
2. **What went wrong?**
3. **What would we change?**
4. **What did we learn?**

Write it down. Update your playbook.

Summary: Problem Resolution

Problem	Solution
Weight dispute	Certified scale, re-weigh once
Bracket error	Floor manager fixes before match
No-show	Call 3 times, default after 2 min
Referee absent	Backup ref on call
Tech failure	Paper backup, manual scoring
Complaint	Floor manager handles privately

Next Section: Part 4

Chapter 14: Immediate Post-Event Chapter 15: 48-Hour Follow Up Chapter 16: Long-Term Analysis

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Template Note: Add problem escalation flowchart to Appendix A.#
Chapter 14: Immediate Post-Event

Right After the Last Match

The event ends, but your work isn’t done. Here’s what to do immediately after.

The Closing Hour

Final Matches Complete

- Award ceremony
- Final announcements
- Thank you to staff
- Next event announcement

Immediately After

1. **Finalize results**
   - Enter all results in TrackWrestling
   - Verify complete
   - Publish live results
2. **Staff payment**
   - Pay referees
   - Pay table workers
   - Thank them personally
   - Schedule next event for reliable staff
3. **Venue teardown**
   - Collect all equipment
   - Clean up venue
   - Return venue to normal configuration
   - Check for lost items
4. **Staff debrief (quick)**
   - What went well?
   - What needs improvement?
   - Thank everyone

Checklist: Post-Event (Same Day)

- ☐ All results entered in TrackWrestling
- ☐ Results published online
- ☐ Staff paid
- ☐ Equipment packed
- ☐ Venue cleaned
- ☐ Venue inspected
- ☐ Any lost items collected
- ☐ Security deposit (if applicable)

Next Chapter

Chapter 15: 48-Hour Follow Up — Communicating after the event.

Template Note: Add post-event checklist to Appendix C.# Chapter 15: 48-Hour Follow Up

The Critical Window

The 48 hours after your event are crucial for building repeat customers. Here’s how to capitalize.

Thank You Email (Within 24 Hours)

Template

> Subject: Thank You from [Event Name]!
>
> Hey Families!
>
> THANK YOU for joining us at [Event Name]!

> We hope you had a great experience. Our goal is always to provide the best tournament experience possible — and we're glad you were part of it.
>
> Results are live on our website: [Link]
>
> Our next event is [Date]! Registration opens [Date]. Don't miss it!
>
> See you on the mat! — Tim

Social Media Posts (Within 48 Hours)

Post-Event Content

- Photo gallery from awards
- "Thanks for coming!" message
- Highlights from the event
- Next event announcement

Example Post

> "What an amazing day at [Event Name]! 300+ wrestlers, incredible competition, and the best fans in youth wrestling. Thank you to everyone who came out!
>
> Missed us? Our next event is [Date] — registration opens soon!
>
> #YouthWrestling #[EventName]"

Staff Thank You

Email to Staff

> Subject: Thank You!
>
> Team,
>
> THANK YOU for making [Event Name] a success!
>
> Your hard work made it happen. We couldn't do this without you.
>
> See you at the next event! — [TD Name]

Collecting Feedback

Survey to Distribute

Send to parents 48 hours post-event:

Questions: 1. How likely are you to return to our event? (1-10) 2. What did we do well? 3. What could we improve? 4. Would you recommend us to a friend?

Feedback Review

- Compile all responses

- Look for patterns
- Note what to change
- Thank those who give detailed feedback

Summary: 48-Hour Actions

Timeline	Action
Within 24 hrs	Thank you email
Within 48 hrs	Social media posts
Within 48 hrs	Staff thank you
Within 48 hrs	Send feedback survey

Next Chapter

Chapter 16: Long-Term Analysis — Reviewing metrics and improving year over year.

Template Note: Add thank you email template to Appendix B.#
Chapter 16: Long-Term Analysis

Getting Better Every Year

Your first event won't be your best. Your 50th should be. Here's how to continuously improve.

Metrics to Track

Every Year, Track:

Metric	How to Measure	Goal
Registration count	TrackWrestling total	Growing
Return rate	(Year 2 attendees ÷ Year 1)	80%+
New attendees	First-time registrants	Growing
Net promoter score	Survey question	70%+
Start time accuracy	Planned vs. actual	100% on time
Revenue per event	Total revenue	Growing
Profit margin	(Revenue - Costs) ÷ Revenue	30%+

Year-Over-Year Comparison

Create an Annual Report

Each year, compile:

1. **Registration trends**
2. **Revenue growth**
3. **Profitability changes**
4. **What worked**

5. **What didn't work**

Questions to Answer

- Are we growing?
- Are we profitable?
- Are families returning?
- Are we improving operations?

The Improvement Cycle

```
Year 1 → Track metrics → Identify issues → Fix for Year 2 → Track →
Adjust → Year 3
```

Each event should be better than the last.

Updating Your Playbook

After each event, update your:

- ☐ Checklists (based on what was missed)
- ☐ Templates (based on what didn't work)
- ☐ Staff training (based on issues)
- ☐ Communication (based on feedback)
- ☐ Venue selection (if issues)

Your playbook grows more valuable every year.

Summary: Long-Term

- Track key metrics annually
- Compare year over year
- Fix what didn't work
- Build your playbook
- Never stop improving

Congratulations!

You've completed the Operations Guide. This is the foundation — but it's just the beginning.

Now go run some great events!

Note: Add annual report template to Appendix D.# Chapter 17: Running a Dual Tournament

What Is a Dual Tournament?

A dual tournament is team-vs-team competition where two teams face off in a scheduled match format. Unlike bracket tournaments (single/double elimination), duals are scored on match wins.

Format Overview

Aspect	Details
Teams	Typically 8-16 teams
Format	Each team fields wrestlers at each weight class
Scoring	Most match wins wins the dual
Duration	3-5 hours depending on team size

Key Differences from Bracket Tournaments

Scoring Structure

Bracket Tournament	Dual Tournament
Individual placement	Team score
Medal awards	Team placement
Single elimination possible	Full lineup required
Seeding important	Matchups matter

Match Management

- Every match counts for team score
- Team lineup must be submitted
- Weight classes matter more
- Cannot scratch easily (affects team)

Setting Up a Dual Tournament

Pre-Event Requirements

1. **Team Registration**
   - Collect team registrations
   - Require lineup in advance
   - Know weight classes each team will fill
2. **Venue Setup**
   - Mats in central area
   - Team seating areas
   - Scoring table with PA
   - Scoreboard visible to all
3. **Schedule**
   - Round-robin or bracket format
   - Typically 1 day for duals
   - Set start times (9 AM standard)

Dual Tournament Scoring

Standard Scoring

Result	Points
Win by pin	6 points
Win by tech fall (15+)	5 points

Major decision (8-14)	4 points
Decision (1-7)	3 points
Loss	0 points

Dual Winner

Team with most points after all matches wins the dual.

Alternative: Best-of series (wrestle 3, win 2)

Team Management

Pre-Dual Communication

- Confirm teams attending
- Collect lineup from each coach
- Verify weights
- Set schedule for weigh-ins

Day-of Procedures

- Team check-in
- Weigh-ins (may differ from bracket events)
- Team lineup submission
- Bracket/bracket generation
- Scoring updates after each round

Special Considerations for Duals

Venue Space

Duals need less space than big bracket tournaments, but more team areas: - Bleacher space for teams - Warm-up area for each team - Coaching area

Timing

Duals typically run faster: - Quick matches - No long breaks between rounds - Set schedule per round

Awards

- Team awards (1st, 2nd, 3rd)
- Individual awards may vary
- Often simpler than bracket events

Summary: Duals

Aspect	Key Point
Format	Team vs team
Scoring	Match wins = team points
Setup	Requires team lineup submissions

Venue	Needs team seating areas
Duration	3-5 hours

Next Chapter

Chapter 18: Weigh-In Systems — Traditional, Virtual, and Satellite weigh-ins.# Chapter 18: Weigh-In Systems

Why Weigh-Ins Matter

Weigh-ins are often where tournaments lose control. Get this wrong, and your entire day is chaotic.

This chapter covers three weigh-in systems: Traditional, Virtual, and Satellite.

Traditional On-Site Weigh-Ins

The Standard Approach

Wrestlers weigh in at the venue, either day-before or day-of.

Day-Before Weigh-Ins

Pros: - Day-of runs smoother - More time for corrections - Less stress for families

Cons: - Staff required night before - Some wrestlers may not make weight

Logistics: - 1-hour window typical - Need 2+ scales - Need volunteers to run - Record weights in system

Day-Of Weigh-Ins

Pros: - No extra day commitment - Can compete at natural weight after cut

Cons: - Creates morning rush - Limited time for corrections - Can delay start if problems

Logistics: - Open 60-90 minutes before first session - Multiple scales needed - Must close before first match

---

Virtual Weigh-In

What Is Virtual Weigh-In?

Wrestlers weigh in at their own facility, verified via video call.

How It Works

1. Wrestler registers for virtual weigh-in
2. Receives appointment time (Google Meet, Zoom)

3. At scheduled time, joins video call
4. Shows weight on certified scale
5. Staff verifies and records
6. Wrestler receives verification

Valhalla's Virtual Weigh-In (From Real Experience)

Requirements: - Must weigh at school/team facility - Must use certified scale (no bathroom scales) - Must be in singlet - Must have Google Meet app - Max 4 wrestlers per appointment

Fee: $20 (covers admin costs)

Satellite Weigh-In

What Is Satellite?

Wrestlers weigh in at another tournament the day before — official weights transferred to your event.

How It Works

1. Partner with another tournament
2. Wrestlers weigh in at that event
3. That tournament sends official weights
4. You verify and accept
5. No second weigh-in needed

Best Practices

- Only accept verified official weights
- Get weights in writing (email)
- Have backup if transfer fails

Weigh-In Best Practices

The Weigh-In Station

Item	Requirement
Certified scale	Required
Backup scale	Recommended
Table	For processing
Volunteers	2-4 people
Forms	Weight sheets
Wristbands	For verified wrestlers

Processing Flow

1. Wrestler arrives at station
2. Shows ID/confirmation
3. Steps on scale
4. Volunteer records weight
5. Volunteer applies wristband
6. Wrestler clears station

Handling Weight Disputes

The Protocol

1. **Request for re-weigh:**
   - Allow one re-weigh in singlet only
   - No clothes, no shoes
   - Same scale, same official
2. **Verification:**
   - Check original entry
   - Check scale accuracy
   - Document all weigh-ins
3. **Decision:**
   - Floor manager makes final call
   - If disputed weight confirmed, wrestler placed accordingly
   - Document everything

Weigh-In Summary

System	Pros	Cons
Traditional (day-before)	Smooth day-of	Extra day
Traditional (day-of)	No extra trip	Morning rush
Virtual	No travel	Requires tech
Satellite	Convenient	Requires partner

Next Chapter

Chapter 19: Volunteer Management — Recruiting, training, and retaining volunteers.

Template Note: Add weigh-in checklist to Appendix C.# Chapter 19: Volunteer Management

Volunteers Are the Backbone

You can’t run a tournament without help. But managing volunteers is a skill. Get it right, and they keep coming back. Get it wrong, and you’ll never see them again.

Where Volunteers Fit

Volunteer Roles vs. Paid Staff

Role Type	Typical Roles
Paid	Referees, head table
Volunteer	Table workers, runners, registration, awards

Most events use volunteers for: - Table workers - Runners - Registration help - Awards distribution - Concessions

---

Recruiting Volunteers

Where to Find Them

1. **Wrestling families**
   - Parents often want to help
   - Even better: require volunteer hours
   - Good fit for team fundraising
2. **Local high schools**
   - Student volunteers
   - Community service hours
   - Good for concession sales
3. **College programs**
   - College wrestlers looking for experience
   - May work for experience/letter
4. **Community service groups**
   - Boy Scouts, Girl Scouts
   - National Honor Society
   - Local clubs

Recruiting Strategies

- **At your own events:** Ask parents at registration
- **Through clubs:** Partner with local clubs for volunteers
- **Social media:** Post call for volunteers
- **School networks:** Connect with athletic departments

Training Volunteers

Basic Training Requirements

For table workers specifically:

1. **What to expect** (from Tim's actual instructions)
   - This will be easy to learn
   - Training provided morning-of
   - You don't need to know wrestling rules
2. **Key procedures:**
   - Identify each wrestler (red vs green)
   - Click save result
   - Never use back button
   - Report errors to head table
3. **Communication:**
   - Mat Chat for calling wrestlers
   - Where to stand
   - When to take breaks

Training Day-of

- 15-minute briefing
- Assign position
- Show what to do
- Have them shadow experienced worker

Scheduling Volunteers

Volunteer Shift Guidelines

- **Maximum shift:** 4-6 hours
- **Break:** 30 minutes required
- **Water/snacks:** Always available
- **Designated break area:** Required

Creating Shift Schedule

Time Block	Position	Volunteer Count
7:30-12:00	Morning session	6-8
12:00-5:00	Afternoon session	6-8
5:00-close	Evening session	4-6

Volunteer Retention

How to Keep Them Coming Back

1. Treat them well - Thank them sincerely - Feed them (meals included) - Appreciate their time

2. Make it easy - Clear instructions - Minimal hassle - Know their role before arrival

3. Recognize contribution - Public thank yous - Social media shoutouts - Small swag (t-shirt, sticker)

4. Provide value - Community connection - Resume builder for students - Good experience

---

Volunteer Management Summary

Aspect	Best Practice
Recruiting	Through wrestling families
Training	Morning-of, 15 min
Scheduling	4-6 hour max shifts
Retention	Thank, feed, appreciate

Next Chapter

Chapter 20: Budgeting & Pricing — Making your tournament financially sustainable.

Template Note: Add volunteer scheduling template to Appendix A.#
Chapter 20: Budgeting & Pricing

The Bottom Line

A tournament that doesn't make money won't survive. This chapter shows you how to price for profit — without charging families too much.

Understanding Your Costs

Fixed Costs (Don't Change with Attendance)

Cost	Typical Amount
Venue rental	$1,500-3,000
Insurance	$200-500
TrackWrestling	$150-300
Awards (base order)	$800-1,500
Marketing	$100-300
Total Fixed	$2,750-5,600

Variable Costs (Scale with Attendance)

Cost	Per Unit
Referee pay	$20-30/hour
Table worker pay	$15-20/hour
Extra awards	$3-5/wrestler
Food for staff	$100-200
Total Variable	~$10-15/wrestler

The Break-Even Formula

```
Break-Even = Fixed Costs ÷ (Entry Fee - Variable Cost per Wrestler)
```

Example

- Fixed costs: $4,000
- Entry fee: $55
- Variable per wrestler: $12

```
Break-Even = $4,000 ÷ ($55 - $12) = 93 wrestlers
```

What it means: You need 93 wrestlers just to break even. Below that, you lose money.

Pricing Strategy

Pricing Tiers

Tier	Price Point	When to Use
Early Bird	$45-50	First 50-100 registrants
Regular	$55-65	Standard pricing
Day-of	$75-85	Limited spots, last minute

Factors That Affect Pricing

- **Regional norms:** What do similar events charge?
- **Value provided:** Are you providing premium experience?
- **Your costs:** Know your break-even first
- **Market position:** Premium events can charge more

Revenue Streams (Beyond Entry Fees)

Additional Revenue Sources

Source	Potential Revenue
Spectator admission	$500-2,000
Concessions	$300-1,500
Vendor fees	$200-1,000
Sponsorship	$500-3,000
Merchandise	$200-500

Pro tip: Don't rely on just entry fees. Build additional revenue into your model.

Budget Template

Sample Budget

Category	Budget	Actual
Venue	$2,000	
Insurance	$300	
Awards	$1,200	
Referees	$1,600	
Table workers	$800	
Staff food	$150	
Marketing	$150	
Misc	$200	
Total	$6,400	

Profit Calculation

```
Revenue - Costs = Profit

Example:
300 wrestlers × $55 = $16,500
+ $1,500 spectators = $18,000
- $6,400 costs = $11,600 profit
```

Financial Best Practices

Must-Do Financial Habits

1. **Know your break-even number**

    - Calculate before pricing
    - Adjust if needed
2. **Track actual vs. budget**
    - Compare after every event
    - Look for variances
3. **Build cash reserve**
    - Save 10% of profits
    - For emergencies/cancellations
4. **Separate business/personal**
    - Business account
    - Track all expenses

Summary: Budget & Pricing

Concept	Key Takeaway
Break-even	Know the number before pricing
Pricing tiers	Early bird → Regular → Day-of
Multiple streams	Don't rely only on entry fees
Track financials	Compare actual to budget

Guide Complete!

This concludes the core chapters of the Operations Guide. You now have the foundation to run professional, profitable wrestling tournaments.

Next steps: - Add appendices (templates, checklists, forms) - Add bonus sections (Scaling, Regional, Tech Stack) - Format for publication - Launch!

Template Note: Add budget template to Appendix D.